KEY TOPIC 2: HITLER'S RISE TO POWER, 1919-33

Paper 3: Weimar and Nazi Germany, 1918-39



COURSE TEXTBOOK

Enquiry: *From Democracy to Dictatorship: How did Hitler destroy the Weimar Republic?*

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L1: KT2.1: The Early Development of the Nazi Party, 1919–1922

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- [ ] Demonstrate precise knowledge of the 25-Point Programme and explain how it was designed to appeal to multiple different groups in German society.
- [ ] Analyse the methods Adolf Hitler used to take total control of the party, including his public speaking, party restructuring, and early propaganda.
- [ ] Evaluate the role and impact of the SA (Sturmabteilung), explaining how political violence became a core tactic of the early Nazi Party.

Recall & Retrieval

1. What was the Spartacist Uprising (1919)?

2. Who led the Spartacist Uprising?

3. Who were the Freikorps?

4. What was the Kapp Putsch (1920)?

5. How did the government defeat the Kapp Putsch?

6. How much were the reparations set at?

7. What was the War Guilt Clause?

8. What was Article 48?

9. What was the 'stab in the back' myth?

10. What is a 'republic'?

Vocabulary Check

The Odd One Out: *Circle ONE term that does not belong with the others. Explain your reasoning: What historical connection links the other terms, and why is your chosen term different?*

DAP (German Workers' Party) | NSDAP (National Socialist German Workers' Party) | 25-Point Programme | Nationalism | Socialism | SA (Sturmabteilung) | Stosstrupp (Shock Troop) | Völkischer Beobachter

Teacher Model / Pupil Reasoning:



In 1919, Germany was in chaos following the end of the First World War. In Munich (the capital city of the Bavaria region), a railway mechanic named Anton Drexler founded a small, extreme right-wing group called the German Workers' Party (DAP). They hated the Weimar Republic, despised the Treaty of Versailles, and blamed Jewish people for Germany's problems. In September 1919, the regular German

army sent an intelligence officer named Adolf Hitler to attend a DAP meeting in a Munich beer hall to spy on them. However, Hitler found that he strongly agreed with their extreme views. Impressed by Hitler's passionate public speaking during a debate, Drexler invited him to join. Hitler left the army and became the party's 55th member.

> **Lived Experience: Kurt Ludecke (Early Nazi Party supporter, describing hearing Hitler speak in Munich, 1922)**
> "My critical faculty was swept away. He was holding the masses, and me with them, under a hypnotic spell by the sheer force of his conviction and intense passion."

Hitler's rapid rise within the DAP was largely driven by his unique talent as a public speaker. At a time when traditional politicians were often dry and academic, Hitler's speeches were rehearsed, theatrical performances. He typically began quietly before gradually building to a screaming, passionate frenzy, using aggressive hand gestures to captivate his audience. He brilliantly tapped into the collective anger of the Munich crowds, offering them simple, clear scapegoats for their misery: the 'November Criminals', the Communists, and the Jews. It was his star power as an orator that drew in crowds and donations, making him so valuable that he could demand total obedience from the party.

Hitler quickly became the DAP's head of propaganda. In February 1920, Hitler and Drexler wrote the 25-Point Programme, a manifesto detailing the party's exact policies. The programme was deliberately designed as a 'catch-all' document to appeal to a wide variety of angry Germans across completely different social classes: * **Nationalist ideas (Appealing to the military, businesses, and traditionalists):** The complete scrapping of the Treaty of Versailles; the demand for Lebensraum (living space) to expand Germany's borders and feed its people. * **Socialist ideas (Appealing to poor, working-class labourers):** The nationalisation of large industries; sharing corporate profits with the workers; expanding old-age pensions. * **Anti-Semitic ideas:** The revoking of German citizenship for all Jews; the demand that only those of 'German blood' could be members of the nation.

Recognising his own importance, Hitler forced Drexler out and became the undisputed leader of the party in July 1921. He immediately began reshaping the party into a highly organised machine: * **Rebranding:** He changed the party's name to the NSDAP (National Socialist German Workers' Party). The inclusion of both 'National' and 'Socialist' was a calculated move to draw voters from both the extreme right and the extreme left. * **The Swastika:** Hitler designed a striking new logo—the Swastika—and adopted the straight-armed Roman salute, giving the party a unique, recognizable visual identity. * **Administrative Reorganisation:** In January 1920, the party set up its first permanent headquarters in Munich and appointed a full-time, salaried administrator, Rudolf Schüssler. The party was no longer a loose group of angry men in a beer hall; it now had proper files, organised membership lists, and a professional structure. * **Propaganda:** In December 1920, the party bought its own newspaper, the Völkischer Beobachter. By 1921, they were printing 17,000 copies, spreading their message far beyond the beer halls. * **Powerful Allies:** Hitler actively recruited wealthy and influential figures to give the party credibility and funding. This included the First World War fighter pilot hero Hermann Göring, the wealthy publisher Julius Streicher, and the charismatic Rudolf Hess.

As the party grew, its meetings were frequently targeted by rival political groups, especially communists. In 1921, Hitler established the Sturmabteilung (SA), or 'Storm Detachment'. Dressed in distinctive brown uniforms, they were known as the 'Brownshirts'. Commanded by a ruthless ex-army captain named Ernst Röhm, the SA recruited heavily from the demobilised Freikorps, right-wing students, and unemployed ex-soldiers. They had two main jobs: to protect Nazi speakers at party meetings, and to violently disrupt the meetings of their political opponents. However, while the SA successfully dominated the streets of Munich, they presented a hidden problem for Hitler. The 'Brownshirts' were fiercely loyal to their own commander, Ernst Röhm, rather than to Hitler himself. Recognising this threat to his absolute authority, Hitler formed a smaller, elite unit from highly trusted members of the SA in 1923, known as the Stosstrupp (Shock Troop). This unit acted as his dedicated personal bodyguard, demonstrating his relentless desire to maintain total dominance over his own movement.

While the creation of the 25-Point Programme, the newspaper, and the SA showed incredible organisation, it is vital to keep the early Nazi Party in perspective. By the end of 1922, they were still fundamentally a regional phenomenon contained within Bavaria. They had roughly 20,000 members, but outside of Munich, they were largely unknown. They did not hold a single seat in the national Reichstag. They had built the machinery for a national movement, but they were not yet a serious threat to the Weimar Republic's existence.

Pair & Share Activity

Q1. Discuss with your partner: Why did the Nazi Party appeal to people in the early 1920s?

The 'But/Because/So' Strategy

Q2. Complete the following sentences based on the provided narrative: 1) Hitler joined the DAP in 1919 BUT... 2) The DAP changed its name to NSDAP in 1920 BECAUSE... 3) The SA was formed in 1921 SO...

Vocabulary in Context

Q3. Write a short paragraph (approx. 75-100 words) describing the early development of the Nazi Party, ensuring you use at least FIVE of the following keywords: DAP, NSDAP, 25-Point Programme, Nationalism, Socialism, SA, Stosstrupp, Völkischer Beobachter.

Causal Linkage

Q4. Explain the causal link between Hitler's leadership and the rapid growth and radicalisation of the Nazi Party between 1919 and 1922. How did his actions directly contribute to these outcomes?

Counter-Factual History

Q5. Imagine that the **SA (Sturmabteilung) was never formed, or was quickly suppressed by authorities, during the 1919-1922 period. How might the early development of the Nazi Party have differed significantly, and what implications would this have had for its ability to gain influence?**

L2: KT2.2: The Munich Putsch and the Lean Years, 1923–1929

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- [ ] Demonstrate precise knowledge of the short-term and long-term causes, events, and immediate consequences of the 1923 Munich Putsch.
- [ ] Analyse how Hitler used his time in prison to write Mein Kampf and fundamentally change the strategy and structure of the Nazi Party.
- [ ] Evaluate why the Nazi Party struggled to win electoral support between 1924 and 1928, despite their highly effective internal reorganisation.

Recall & Retrieval

1. Why did France and Belgium invade the Ruhr in 1923?

2. How did German workers react to the Ruhr invasion?

3. What caused Hyperinflation in 1923?

4. Who suffered most from Hyperinflation?

5. Who benefitted from Hyperinflation?

6. Who were the Freikorps?

7. Who led the Spartacist Uprising?

8. How was the Kapp Putsch defeated?

9. What was Proportional Representation?

10. What were the military restrictions of the Treaty of Versailles?

Vocabulary Check

The Golden Sentence: *Choose TWO terms from the word bank. Write ONE grammatically sophisticated, historically accurate sentence connecting them using a causal conjunction (because, although, or consequently):*

The Bavarian Triumvirate | Treason | Landsberg Prison | Mein Kampf ('My Struggle') | Führerprinzip (The Leadership Principle) | Gauleiter | SS (Schutzstaffel) | Aryan

Teacher Model / Pupil Sentence:



By November 1923, the Weimar Republic appeared to be collapsing. French troops were occupying the Ruhr, hyperinflation had destroyed the currency, and the democratic government in Berlin looked entirely powerless. Hitler believed the time was right to strike, heavily inspired by the Italian fascist leader Benito Mussolini, who had successfully marched on Rome and seized power the year before. In Bavaria, the local right-wing government—led by the **Triumvirate** of Gustav von Kahr (Bavarian Prime Minister), Otto

von Lossow (head of the Bavarian army), and Hans von Seisser (head of the Bavarian police)—was also actively plotting against the Weimar government. Hitler intended to hijack their plot, use their authority to take control of Munich, and then march his SA stormtroopers to Berlin to tear down the Republic.

> **Lived Experience: Egon Hanfstaengl (Eyewitness to the Munich Putsch in the Bürgerbräukeller, 8 November 1923)**
> "Hitler jumped onto a chair, fired a pistol shot into the ceiling, and cried in a hoarse voice: 'The National Revolution has broken out! The Bavarian government is deposed!' For a moment there was stunned, deathly silence."

On the evening of **8 November 1923**, the Bavarian Triumvirate were speaking at a meeting in the Bürgerbräukeller (a large beer hall) in Munich. Hitler, backed by 600 armed SA members, burst through the doors. He fired a gunshot into the ceiling and declared a national revolution. At gunpoint, he forced Kahr, Lossow, and Seisser into a back room and made them swear loyalty to his uprising. Crucially, Hitler also had the backing of **General Erich Ludendorff**, a highly respected First World War military hero. However, the Putsch quickly unravelled. Hitler made a fatal error by leaving the beer hall to deal with a crisis elsewhere, allowing Ludendorff to let the Triumvirate go home. Once free, Kahr and Lossow immediately broke their promises and contacted the regular army and police to stop the Nazis. On **9 November**, Hitler and Ludendorff marched 2,000 Nazis into the centre of Munich. They were met by armed police. A brief, bloody firefight broke out. Fourteen Nazis and four policemen were killed. Hitler dislocated his shoulder, fled the scene, and was arrested two days later hiding in a wardrobe.

On the surface, the Putsch was a humiliating failure. The Nazi Party was banned, and Hitler was put on trial for high treason. However, Hitler turned his trial into a political masterstroke. The trial gave Hitler national media coverage for the very first time. He used the courtroom as a theatrical stage, delivering passionate speeches arguing that he wasn't a traitor, but a patriot trying to save Germany from the "treasonous 'November Criminals'". The Weimar judiciary (judges) were traditionally very right-wing and sympathised with his hatred of the Republic. Instead of the death penalty (the standard punishment for treason), Hitler was given a remarkably lenient sentence of just five years in **Landsberg Prison**. In reality, he served only **nine months** in comfortable conditions. He spent this time dictating his manifesto, ***Mein Kampf* (My Struggle)**. This book laid out his core beliefs, which would become the blueprint for Nazi Germany: * **Race:** The belief that the Germanic **Aryan** race was superior and destined to rule, while Jewish people were part of a global conspiracy plotting to weaken Germany. * **Lebensraum (Living Space):** The necessity of expanding Germany's borders into Eastern Europe and Russia to gain land and resources. * **Totalitarianism:** The destruction of democracy in favour of the **Führerprinzip** (the total authority of a single leader).

While in prison, Hitler realised a crucial lesson: the Nazis could no longer try to seize power by force. They had to destroy democracy from the inside by winning elections—what he called the **"legal route"** to power: *"We shall have to hold our noses and enter the Reichstag."* Upon his release in December 1924, the ban on the Nazi Party was lifted, and Hitler set about drastically reorganising the political machine: ***National Structure:*** *He divided Germany into 35 local regions (*Gaue*), appointing a loyal **Gauleiter** to run each one and drive local recruitment. * **The SS:** Because the SA was too rowdy and heavily loyal to Ernst Röhm, Hitler created the **SS (Schutzstaffel)** in 1925. Run by **Heinrich Himmler**, they wore black uniforms and acted as Hitler's fiercely loyal, elite personal bodyguards. ***Targeting the Youth:*** *In 1926, the party officially formed the **Hitler Youth** (*Hitlerjugend*) to indoctrinate young boys, alongside the Nazi Women's League.

As the party expanded nationally, a dangerous split emerged. The northern Gauleiters (like Gregor Strasser and Joseph Goebbels) wanted to focus heavily on the 'Socialist' parts of the 25-Point Programme to win over poor industrial workers. The southern Gauleiters wanted to focus on the 'Nationalist' parts to win over wealthy businessmen and the army. To prevent the party from fracturing, Hitler called the **Bamberg Conference** in 1926. He ruthlessly crushed the socialist wing of the party, asserting his absolute authority. Recognising talent, Hitler cleverly won over **Joseph Goebbels**, promoting him to Gauleiter of Berlin. Strasser was sidelined, and Hitler’s total ideological dominance was secured.

Despite having over 100,000 highly disciplined members by 1928, the Nazis were an electoral failure, winning just 12 seats (2.6% of the vote) in the 1928 Reichstag elections. The primary reason for this failure was Gustav Stresemann. The Weimar Republic was experiencing an economic 'Golden Age'. Hyperinflation was over, American Dawes Plan loans were flowing in, and in 1925, the German people had elected the conservative war hero Paul von Hindenburg as President. With the country feeling stable and proud, voters simply ignored the extreme politics of the Nazi Party. However, the Nazis were highly adaptable. Realising that industrial workers were voting for the Communists or Social Democrats, the Nazis shifted their propaganda. They began heavily targeting **farmers** (who were suffering from plummeting food prices) and the **lower-middle classes** (the *Mittelstand*, who had never recovered from hyperinflation). While they failed to win power in 1928, the Nazis had built a highly organised, national political machine just waiting for the next major crisis to strike.

Pair & Share Activity

Q1. Discuss with your partner: Was the Munich Putsch a total failure for Hitler?

The 'But/Because/So' Strategy

Q2. Complete the following sentences based on the lesson narrative:
1. Hitler's Munich Putsch failed to seize power in 1923, BUT...
2. Hitler received a lenient sentence for treason BECAUSE...
3. During his time in Landsberg Prison, Hitler wrote *Mein Kampf*, SO...

Vocabulary in Context

Q3. Using at least FOUR of the following keywords – *Mein Kampf*, Führerprinzip, Gauleiter, SS, Aryan, Landsberg Prison, Treason – explain how Hitler used his time in prison and the subsequent "Lean Years" to reshape the Nazi Party and its ideology.

Causal Linkage

Q4. Explain how the failure of the Munich Putsch and Hitler's subsequent imprisonment, despite being a setback, ultimately strengthened his position and the long-term trajectory of the Nazi Party.

The 'What If' Challenge

Q5. Imagine a counter-factual scenario where the Bavarian Triumvirate (Kahr, Lossow, Seisser) had *not* reneged on their initial agreement with Hitler during the Munich Putsch, and instead had supported his 'national revolution'. What might have been the immediate and long-term consequences for Germany, the Weimar Republic, and the rise of Nazism? Consider both political and social impacts.

L3: KT2.3: The Growth of Nazi Support, 1929–1932

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- [ ] Demonstrate precise knowledge of the economic and social impacts of the 1929 Wall Street Crash on Germany.
- [ ] Analyse the political paralysis of the Weimar Republic, explaining why the collapse of Müller's coalition and Brüning's policies caused voters to flock to extremist parties.
- [ ] Evaluate the reasons for the surge in Nazi support, judging the relative importance of Hitler's personal appeal, Goebbels' propaganda, Big Business funding, and the violence of the SA.

Recall & Retrieval

1. Who became Chancellor in 1923 and helped end hyperinflation?

2. What new currency did Stresemann introduce in 1923?

3. What was the Dawes Plan (1924)?

4. What was the Young Plan (1929)?

5. What was the Locarno Pact (1925)?

6. Why did France invade the Ruhr in 1923?

7. What was passive resistance?

8. Who suffered most from hyperinflation?

9. What was the Kapp Putsch?

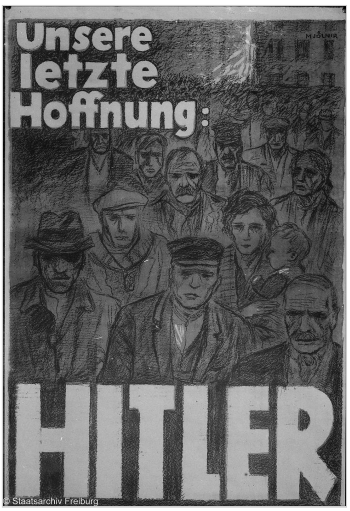
10. What was Article 231?

Vocabulary Check

Conceptual Classification: *Categorise the terms from the word bank into the two historical boxes below:*

The Wall Street Crash | KPD (Communist Party of Germany) | Hermann Müller | Heinrich Brüning | Article 48 | Negative Cohesion | Rotfrontkämpferbund (Red Front Fighters' League)

Power, Governance & Warfare	Economy, Trade & Society



In October 1929, the US stock market collapsed, triggering the **Wall Street Crash**. Gustav Stresemann's warning that Germany was "dancing on a volcano" became a terrifying reality. Under the Dawes Plan of 1924, the German economy was entirely reliant on American loans. Following the crash, panicked American banks demanded their money back immediately. The economic impact on Germany was catastrophic. Without American investment, German factories were forced to shut down. By 1932, unemployment had reached a staggering **6 million** (roughly 40% of the German workforce). Millions were

left homeless, relying on soup kitchens and sleeping in parks. Crucially, the middle classes—who had already lost their savings during the 1923 hyperinflation crisis—found themselves facing ruin once again as businesses and banks collapsed.

> **Lived Experience: Heinrich Hauser (German journalist describing the breadlines during the Great Depression, 1932)**
> "An almost unbroken chain of homeless men and women were tramping along the highway. They had the blank eyes of starved animals. When Hitler promised work and bread, he was speaking to people with nothing left to lose."

As the economic crisis deepened, the Weimar political system completely paralysed. The Chancellor, a Social Democrat named **Hermann Müller**, led a 'Grand Coalition' of moderate parties. However, as unemployment skyrocketed, the politicians bitterly argued over whether to raise taxes or cut unemployment benefits. Unable to agree, Müller resigned in March 1930. This marked the end of truly democratic government in Weimar Germany. He was replaced by **Heinrich Brüning**. Because Brüning could not get a majority in the Reichstag, he relied on President Hindenburg to pass laws using **Article 48** (emergency decrees). **Advanced Analysis: The 'Hunger Chancellor'** Brüning's response to the crisis was disastrous. Fearing a repeat of the 1923 hyperinflation, he refused to print more money. Instead, he raised taxes, slashed government wages, and cut unemployment benefits. This caused immense suffering, earning him the bitter nickname the **'Hunger Chancellor'**. With the moderate government actively making the people poorer and bypassing parliament, desperate Germans began to abandon democracy entirely and vote for extreme parties who promised radical solutions.

The first group to benefit from this desperation was the **KPD (Communist Party)**. Unemployed, starving industrial workers flocked to the KPD, which promised to overthrow the wealthy industrialists and share the nation's wealth equally. By 1932, the KPD had gained 100 seats in the Reichstag. However, this surge in communist support terrified the German middle classes, rural farmers, and wealthy business owners. Rich industrialists like **Fritz Thyssen**, the Krupp family, and Bosch were terrified of a Russian-style revolution where their factories would be confiscated. Consequently, they began secretly pouring millions of marks into the Nazi Party, viewing Hitler as their best defence against the Communists. This massive financial backing allowed Joseph Goebbels to fund an unparalleled propaganda campaign.

Using this new wealth, the Nazis presented themselves as the only political force strong enough to save Germany. ***The 1932 Presidential Election:*** *Hitler challenged the ageing Hindenburg for the presidency. Although Hitler lost, he won an astonishing* ***13.4 million votes****. This campaign catapulted him to national superstar status. He was the first politician to fly by aeroplane to multiple cities in a single day (the* "Hitler over Germany"* campaign), giving him the image of a dynamic, energetic saviour. ***Targeted Propaganda:*** *Nazi propaganda was highly sophisticated. If an anti-Semitic poster didn't work in a certain town, they quietly dropped it and used a poster promising higher crop prices for farmers instead. They promised* 'Work and Bread'* to the unemployed. * **Appealing to Demographics:** They successfully targeted **women** by claiming that voting for the Nazis was the best way to protect traditional family values and save their children from starvation. They targeted **young people** by portraying the Weimar Republic as weak and elderly, and the Nazi movement as exciting and rebellious.

The growth of the Nazi Party was not just about brilliant posters; it was deeply rooted in violence and **negative cohesion**. By 1932, the SA had grown to 400,000 members. Germany's streets were erupting into open warfare as the SA fought brutal battles against the communist private army, the *Rotfrontkämpferbund*. Dozens of people were killed in political street fights. Paradoxically, the Nazis used this violence to their advantage. They deliberately started the fights with the communists, but then used their highly disciplined, uniformed SA marches to present themselves to the middle classes as the only party capable of restoring order. Millions of middle-class voters ultimately voted for the Nazis not because they fully supported Hitler's extreme racial views, but because of *negative cohesion*—they shared Hitler's hatred of the Weimar Republic and his absolute determination to crush the communists.

Pair & Share Activity

Q1. Discuss with your partner: Why did Nazi support surge after 1929?

The 'But/Because/So' Strategy

Q2. Complete the following sentences based on the lesson narrative: 1) The Grand Coalition government under Hermann Müller collapsed BUT... 2) Heinrich Brüning increasingly relied on Article 48 BECAUSE... 3) Nazi support grew dramatically between 1929 and 1932 SO...

Vocabulary in Context

Q3. Write a short paragraph (approximately 100-150 words) explaining the political and economic crisis in Germany between 1929-1932, accurately using at least five of the following keywords: Wall Street Crash, Hermann Müller, Heinrich Brüning, Article 48, KPD, Negative Cohesion, Rotfrontkämpferbund.

Prioritising Causes

Q4. Identify and explain the *two most significant* reasons for the rapid growth of Nazi support between 1929 and 1932, justifying your choices with specific evidence from the lesson narrative.

Counter-Factual History

Q5. "If the Wall Street Crash had not occurred in October 1929, the Nazis would never have come to power." To what extent do you agree with this statement? Justify your answer with reference to the lesson narrative, considering both arguments for and against the statement.

L4: KT2.4: How Hitler Became Chancellor, 1932–1933

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- [ ] Demonstrate precise chronological knowledge of the rapid succession of Weimar Chancellors between 1930 and 1933 (Brüning, von Papen, von Schleicher).
- [ ] Analyse the political scheming ("backstairs intrigue") between President Hindenburg, his inner circle, Franz von Papen, and the conservative elites.
- [ ] Evaluate why Hindenburg finally agreed to appoint Hitler as Chancellor despite his deep personal hatred for him, understanding the fatal miscalculation the elites made.

Recall & Retrieval

1. When did Germany join the League of Nations?

2. What was the Kellogg-Briand Pact (1928)?

3. Why did the 'Golden Age' (1924-29) rely on 'dancing on a volcano'?

4. How did culture change during the Golden Age?

5. What did Stresemann introduce to fix hyperinflation?

6. What was the Dawes Plan?

7. What was the Young Plan?

8. What was the Locarno Pact?

9. Why did the French invade the Ruhr?

10. Who were the November Criminals?

Vocabulary Check

Spot the Deliberate Error: *Read the statement below. One historical fact or vocabulary concept has been deliberately falsified. Underline the error and explain the accurate historical reality below:*

Paul von Hindenburg | The Camarilla | Franz von Papen | Kurt von Schleicher | Backstairs Intrigue | Cabinet

> *"In January 1933, President Paul von Hindenburg appointed Adolf Hitler Chancellor following a nationwide democratic election victory, rejecting all Backstairs Intrigue from Franz von Papen and the Camarilla."*

Teacher Model / Historical Correction:



By the spring of 1932, the Weimar Constitution was effectively broken. Chancellor Heinrich Brüning had lost control of the Reichstag and was relying entirely on President Hindenburg to pass laws using **Article 48** (emergency decrees). In May 1932, Brüning made two fatal miscalculations. First, to curb street

violence, he banned the SA and the SS, which outraged right-wing politicians. Second, he proposed buying up bankrupt country estates from the wealthy elite to house unemployed workers. Hindenburg, himself a wealthy landowner, was furious and viewed this as practically communist. Brüning was forced to resign.

> **Lived Experience: Franz von Papen (Conservative Vice-Chancellor, boasting to friends in January 1933)**
> "No danger at all. We have hired Hitler for our purpose. Within two months, we will have pushed him so far into a corner that he'll squeak!"

Hindenburg was advised by General Kurt von Schleicher to appoint a wealthy, conservative nobleman named **Franz von Papen** as the new Chancellor. Papen's government was incredibly undemocratic; it was made up entirely of wealthy landowners and industrial elites, earning it the nickname the **'Cabinet of Barons'**. Because Papen had almost no support in the Reichstag, he held a general election in **July 1932**, hoping to win a majority. It was a disaster for him, but a triumph for the Nazis. The Nazi Party won **230 seats**, making them the largest single party in the Reichstag. Hitler immediately demanded that Hindenburg make him Chancellor. Hindenburg, who openly despised Hitler (referring to him insultingly as "that Bohemian corporal"), flatly refused.

Refusing to cooperate, the Nazis and Communists used their majority to vote down everything Papen proposed. Paralyzed, Papen convinced Hindenburg to call *another* election in **November 1932**, hoping the voters were getting tired of the Nazis. Papen was partially right. In November, the Nazi vote dropped to **196 seats**. Furthermore, the Nazis had fought three major election campaigns in one year; party funds were completely exhausted, and Goebbels wrote in his diary of deep despair. The Nazi momentum was breaking. At this critical moment, big business intervened. Terrified of a communist takeover, wealthy industrialists (organised by Hjalmar Schacht) sent Hindenburg a formal petition demanding he appoint Hitler as Chancellor to protect their wealth.

Fearing that keeping Papen in power would cause the SA to start a civil war, Hindenburg sacked Papen and reluctantly made General **Kurt von Schleicher** Chancellor in December 1932. Schleicher's time as Chancellor was a complete failure. He had no political support and could not control the Reichstag. Meanwhile, a furious and humiliated Franz von Papen wanted revenge against Schleicher. Papen began a **'backstairs intrigue'**—secretly meeting with Adolf Hitler, alongside members of Hindenburg's **camarilla** (his son Oskar von Hindenburg and advisor Otto von Meissner). They struck a backroom deal: if Papen could convince the ageing President to make Hitler Chancellor, Hitler would make Papen Vice-Chancellor.

On **30 January 1933**, President Hindenburg officially appointed Adolf Hitler as Chancellor of Germany. To a modern historian, it seems unbelievable that the conservative elites would hand power to a violent extremist. However, they believed they had trapped Hitler in a political cage. Out of a Cabinet of 12 ministers, Hindenburg and Papen allowed **only two other Nazis** (Wilhelm Frick and Hermann Göring); the rest were traditional conservatives. The elites severely underestimated Hitler, viewing him as an uneducated political amateur they could easily manipulate to crush the communists. Papen famously boasted to a friend: *"We have framed him... in two months we will have pushed Hitler into a corner so hard that he'll be squeaking."* They believed they were hiring Hitler as their puppet; in reality, they had just handed him the keys to the Republic.

Pair & Share Activity

Q1. Discuss with your partner: Did Hitler seize power or was it handed to him?

The 'But/Because/So' Strategy

Q2. Complete the following sentences based on the lesson:
1. Kurt von Schleicher became Chancellor in December 1932, BUT...

2. Franz von Papen wanted to get back into power BECAUSE...
3. President Hindenburg ultimately appointed Hitler as Chancellor SO...

Vocabulary in Context

Q3. Write a short paragraph (5-7 sentences) explaining how Hitler became Chancellor, making sure to use ALL the following keywords: Paul von Hindenburg, The Camarilla, Franz von Papen, Kurt von Schleicher, Backstairs Intrigue, Cabinet. You may underline or bold the keywords in your answer.

Prioritising Causes

Q4. Of the factors described in the lesson, which do you think was the *most* important in Hitler becoming Chancellor? Explain your reasoning. Then, identify one *other* important factor and explain its significance.

Counter-Factual History

Q5. Imagine that President Hindenburg had refused to meet with Franz von Papen and Hitler in early January 1933, or had simply dismissed Papen's proposals outright. What do you think would have been the most likely immediate political consequences for Germany? Consider the roles of Schleicher, the Nazi Party, and the broader political climate.